

Tor Vergata University of Rome



TOR VERGATA
UNIVERSITÀ DEGLI STUDI DI ROMA

FACULTY OF ENGINEERING

**COMPUTER SCIENCE, CONTROL AND GEOINFORMATION
CYCLE XXXVII**

PhD Thesis

**A UNIFIED SOFTWARE ARCHITECTURE FOR
DISTRIBUTED AUTONOMOUS SYSTEMS**

ADVISOR

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CANDIDATE

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COORDINATOR

Prof. Francesco Quaglia

A.Y. 2023/2024



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Wings are a constraint that makes
it possible to fly.
— Robert Bringhurst

Acknowledgements

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Lausanne, 12 Mars 2011

Preface

This is the summary of three years of work spanning multiple areas. From the problem to the solution. It is inevitable to name some tools and concepts before they are explained later on among chapters.

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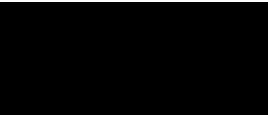
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1 Introduction

In the history of humanity, many turning points have been marked by technological advancements. From the invention of the wheel to the steam engine, from the light bulb to the computer, technology has continuously changed how we live, work, and see the world. Its impact on society has always been profound and sometimes positive, sometimes negative. The changes it brought affected our daily habits, introducing new ways of doing things and sometimes even new ways of thinking. With the same spirit that drove our ancestors to develop *tools* made of stones and sticks to make their lives easier while harvesting food, we are now developing ever more powerful machines of all sorts to handle the challenges of the modern world, which can work either together with a human operator or in complete autonomy. Moreover, considering the recent developments of artificial intelligence, these tools have reached such a level of sophistication that they may soon reshape our thought processes.

The technological advancements that brought us these new solutions increased not only their capabilities but also their complexity and, ultimately, their variety. An excellent example is the industrial manipulator robot: a machine that can perform various tasks, from simple pick-and-place operations to more complex ones such as welding, painting, or even surgery. These machines have evolved from mechanical arms composed of multiple actuators, all connected to a single power and computational unit, to a network of sensors and microcontrollers, grouped in subsystems all

interconnected to a central unit, which is, in turn, responsible for their coordination, supervision, and control, as well as for interfacing with human operators. In this case, this evolution has been driven by the need to increase the robot's capabilities, making it more versatile and adaptable to different tasks, and by the need to make it more reliable and safe, reducing the risk of accidents and downtime due to maintenance. Another suitable example would be the modern airplane: considering even a small civilian aircraft, originally equipped with an engine, control surfaces, and a few instruments, it has evolved into a complex system of systems composed of a multitude of sensors, probes, indicators, and avionics. In this scenario, the evolution has been driven by specific needs still related to safety and comfort but can ultimately be summarized in the need to ease the lives of both the passengers and the crew.

This design and development paradigm has recently become commonly denoted by the adjective *distributed*. The definitive characteristic of a distributed system is its decomposition into a network of subsystems. Each one is responsible for a specific task; all of them are interconnected, and they all perform a piece of the job that the entire macroscopic system has been designed to do. This decomposition allows for more efficient use of the resources, better scalability, and higher reliability, as the failure of a single subsystem does not necessarily lead to the failure of the whole system. Moreover, the distribution of the subsystems allows for a better organization of the system's functionalities, as each subsystem can be designed and developed independently from the others, following a modular approach that eases the task of understanding, controlling, and maintaining the system as a whole. This approach has been widely adopted in many fields, from industrial automation to aerospace, automotive to robotics, telecommunications to energy. Another peculiar characteristic of a distributed system is the possibility, in many contexts, to deploy its parts in different locations: coming back to the manipulator example, it is common to

have the sensors and the actuators distributed along the robot's arm and the control unit placed in a separate location, while in the airplane example, the sensors and the avionics are distributed along the fuselage and the wings, while the cockpit is placed in the front of the aircraft; in pure software systems, the subsystems can be deployed in different servers, data centers, or even continents, with the additional advantage of partitioning the workload generated by the various regions among local computational nodes. These degrees of physical distribution allow great flexibility in design and resource allocation, but they also introduce new challenges in communication, synchronization, and fault tolerance.

All of this innovation comes at a price: when the multitude of subsystems, subcomponents, and submodules increases, new problems arise. The system's complexity grows, and so does the difficulty of understanding, controlling, and maintaining it. The interactions between the different parts of the system become intricate. With strong dependencies among modules and no redundancy, the consequences of a failure in one of them can propagate to the others, causing a cascade of failures that can lead to catastrophic events. A deep understanding is needed to prevent events like these, for which a good organization of the system *architecture* is of paramount importance. Moreover, a well-designed architecture may also be incredibly beneficial in two other stages: the design and development of the system and its maintenance. In the former, a clear and well-structured architecture naturally leads to a clear and well-structured design, following a top-down approach that starts from the system's requirements and ends with the definition of the subsystems and their interfaces, each following a common set of standards and best practices that adhere to the structure of the architecture itself. In the latter, a well-structured architecture allows for a clear identification of the subsystems and their interactions, easing diagnosing and fixing a failure or an error. Finally, a good architecture can also be a powerful resource for the

evolution of the system as a whole, allowing for the addition of new functionalities or the replacement of old components with new ones without the need to redesign the whole system from scratch, significantly reducing the time and the costs of such an operation.

The subject of this work is the development of a software architecture for distributed systems intended to control dynamic processes and autonomous agents. This setting may seem specific, but it is pretty broad: all of the above examples fall into these categories, representing topics of high interest in today's research and industrial environments. All the design and development problems listed above still apply to these cases, which also bring their own specific challenges addressed in the following. The main goal of this work is to provide a unified solution to these problems by defining a software architecture that can be used as a reference for the design and development of distributed systems in the contexts mentioned above. The proposed architecture is designed to be modular and flexible, and it is based on a set of standards and best practices that may guide the development of the subsystems and their interactions. Moreover, the architecture is designed to be adaptable to and deployable on different hardware platforms, to provide an abstraction layer for solutions ranging from embedded systems to general-purpose computers, and to easily integrate other software modules like third-party libraries. Finally, the architecture is built to be easily usable by developers, providing a unified set of tools and utilities that ease the task of developing, testing, and deploying new modules for the classes of systems mentioned above. The end goal of this work comes from a fundamental necessity identified by the author during his experience as a researcher and developer in the field of automation and robotics: having a standard development environment suitable for a single developer or an entire team, capable of replicating almost entirely the system configuration of a target platform on a development machine and enabling distributed applications to

work and behave in the same way on all supported platforms, from build to run time. This way, the integration overhead gets dramatically cut, allowing developers to focus on their most essential and only true task: research and development, leading quickly to new technological advancements.

Just like our primordial ancestors faced the necessity of building tools to ease their lives, this work follows the same approach: identify the problem, lay down the requirements, design the solution, build it, test it, and finally use it. The requirements that drive the design of the architecture are identified and discussed in the following Chapters, and the proposed solutions are based on the state of the art in the field of software engineering and distributed systems, as well as on the author's own practical experience.

2 The importance of an architecture

The development of an autonomous system is a process that involves various stages. Each stage is typically characterized by defining and solving issues related to different aspects of the system, ranging from the tasks it will be required to perform, to its construction and programming, and even to how the data it collects and that affect its operation should be presented to potential operators. Generalizing from a specific application case, most issues can be classified into a few high-level categories. Although it may seem counterintuitive from the division that follows, these categories are not always addressed sequentially, nor are they entirely independent of each other. To address situations like these, various project management techniques have been developed in recent times, aimed at minimizing the risk that an error made in an earlier phase could compromise subsequent stages, potentially undermining finished work and increasing development times. In light of the observations made in Chapter 1, it is clear that, with the increasing complexity of modern automated systems and of the tasks they must perform, these topics are more relevant than ever. In particular, new tools made available to developers and designers will need to reflect these specificities, simplify the management of typical situations where possible, and highlight potential critical issues to aid in problem-solving. Practical experience shows that, despite the variety of cases and applications, the challenges faced are almost always, if not identical, very similar, as are the strategies to address them.

The aim of this chapter is to briefly present the issues typically encountered when designing an autonomous system, highlighting their unique characteristics without focusing on a particular application area, and then to examine some recent hardware and software solutions that enable the optimization of design, development, and testing activities. The discussion starts at a relatively high level of abstraction but becomes progressively more specific, forming the guiding thread that connects all subsequent chapters, finally highlighting the necessity of a well-structured software architecture to address the issues raised. The requirements that such an architecture must meet are then formalized and discussed in due detail.

Before moving further, it is instrumental to clarify the definition of an autonomous system in the context of this work. First of all, in this work the term *system* identifies a macroscopic entity, which can either be entirely hardware, or entirely software, or a mixture of both, that evolves in time and is characterized by a set of inputs and outputs. Its tasks are defined by the operations that it must perform on these inputs to produce the desired outputs, and by the constraints that these operations must satisfy. The system can either be seen as a unitary entity or as a set of *subsystems*, *subcomponents*, and *submodules*, all terms that are used interchangeably in this work, each of which takes care of a part of the processing, thus contributing to a part of the tasks. For the system to work correctly, all the subsystems must do the same and be interconnected accordingly, both in terms of the data they share and of the resources they use. The term *autonomous* refers to the capability of the system to perform these tasks without human intervention, or with minimal human intervention, once it has been set up and started. This definition is intentionally broad and generic, as it is meant to encompass a wide range of applications and scenarios, *e.g.*, from mobile robots to drones, from power plants to industrial automation systems. Another class of systems that is included in this definition and that is of interest in this work is

that of *dynamic systems*, which are systems whose state evolves in time according to a mathematical model that can be either deterministic or stochastic, and that can be either known or unknown. The evolution of the system's state, and thus that of its output, can be influenced by acting accordingly on its input, an operation that is commonly referred to as *controlling* the system or *applying a control law* to the system. In the context of autonomous systems this can be one of the tasks to perform, which is especially true for those systems that have a physical structure that can be modeled as a dynamic system and that should evolve over time according to a specific desired behavior.

2.1 Design challenges

2.1.1 The tasks

The initial decisions in the design of an autonomous system naturally concern the specifications of the operations it will be required to perform. These specifications must be fully defined from the onset, down to the smallest detail possible at this stage, as they will guide all subsequent choices, from hardware selection and construction to programming. During the breakdown of operational requirements into *tasks*, intended as discrete units of work to be executed, various types of these will emerge. Without delving, for now, into the specifics of a particular scenario, common categories of tasks include:

- **Continuous tasks**, which begin at system startup and run uninterrupted until it is turned off or malfunctions.
- **Periodic tasks**, which are performed at regular intervals.

- **Asynchronous tasks**, which are executed only when a specific event occurs, which may or may not ever occur.

It is easy to see that most functionalities in modern autonomous systems can be broken down into tasks that fall within these categories. These include operations ranging from actuator control, to the collection of data and measurements required by control algorithms, to communication with eventual operators and users. The characteristics of these tasks will influence both the hardware that must execute them and the software that encodes them, which should be organized accordingly to facilitate development and maintenance. To allow this organization, the system architecture must efficiently support the development of software modules, and the integration of hardware solutions, that can handle all these kinds of tasks.

2.1.2 The hardware

The next decisions to be made concern the hardware to be used. The choices made initially in this direction may very well not be definitive, since they would concern both the construction of the initial prototypes and the final product: there will likely be misjudgments or unforeseen issues to address down the road. Nevertheless, the hardware must be selected carefully based on the operational, structural, and construction requirements defined so far. Decisions taken in the previous step are of critical importance at this stage: establishing the computational complexity of the operations the system will need to perform will dictate the level of power required from the hardware, which may need to be equipped with discrete coprocessors¹ to handle specific types of data or subdivided into multiple interconnected subsystems.

¹The term *discrete* here refers to auxiliary hardware installed in a computer that cannot operate independently but is designed to be driven by the primary computer, providing specialized support for specific tasks; classic examples include math coprocessors, GPUs, and sound cards.

A market survey is essential to assess whether pre-tested and ready-to-use components or SoCs^{II} could be utilized rather than resorting to a proprietary solution, which generally entails significant development, testing, and validation costs. For the reasons mentioned above, it is very challenging, if not impossible, to outline a comprehensive and definitive list of possible hardware solutions at this point; the priority is to understand what is needed and whether the market offers options compatible with those requirements, while also anticipating potential future demands. Following this approach will allow any subsequent modifications to be managed with minimal effort.

The remaining choices concern lower-level hardware, which generally consists of:

- high-speed microcontrollers;
- actuators;
- sensors;
- interfaces and communication devices;
- data storage systems.

Nothing more can be said about these elements without reference to a specific case; however, practical scenarios discussed later in this work will follow this design pattern. From the multiplicity of devices mentioned up to this point, and that may compose a modern autonomous system, it starts to become clear how the complexity of the system can grow rapidly, as anticipated in Chapter 1. The need for a well-structured architecture to manage this complexity becomes more evident.

^{II}System-on-Chip.

2.1.3 The software

Except for those components that perform crucial and highly specific functions, such as electrical or electronic circuits, nearly all operations carried out by a modern autonomous system are today encoded within an internal computer, which translates these instructions into commands for other components, subsystems, sensors, or actuators. This is not the place to delve into standard software design and development procedures, but it is worth reflecting on one point which has become quite common in present solutions: given the underlying complexity of the system itself, the software that controls it will also have a layered and highly hierarchical organization. In this hierarchy, the lower levels are occupied by modules that must interact with, if not directly control, the smaller and faster subsystems (*e.g.*, firmware), and these modules must be developed with particular attention to their characteristics and purposes. As we move up the hierarchy, we encounter broader modules that encode operations such as supervision, planning, and user communication, making them closer to the notion of *application* or *system software* which end users are more accustomed to as it is the most visible to them.

This context also involves decisions regarding the programming languages to be adopted. As is well known, each language has its unique features, highlighting its strengths as well as weaknesses compared to alternatives. Only a few programming languages are truly suitable for multiple purposes, in the sense of the ease with which they allow different types of tasks to be coded, and none should be considered universal.

When operating in this context, it is essential to rely on tools that simplify design and development as much as possible at all levels, assisting with the management of issues related to module organization, inter- and intra-process communication, data

processing, and storage of various data types. The necessity of a good architecture to handle these new challenges becomes increasingly evident.

2.1.4 The data

For an autonomous system to successfully complete its tasks, it requires a nearly constant stream of information. This information can be received in data packets managed by suitable communication interfaces, or it can be acquired directly through measurement devices, commonly known as *sensors*. For both solutions, typical challenges that arise immediately include the integration of these devices with the rest of the apparatus and the processing of the data they produce. These issues are crucial, as the operation of the entire system is almost always contingent upon obtaining information about measurable quantities of interest and the system's own state^{III}.

It is therefore reasonable to expect that the hardware architecture of a modern autonomous system will comprise numerous communication interfaces and sensors, the latter consisting of specific hardware designed to measure particular physical quantities of interest. The challenges mentioned above pertain to the integration of such hardware with the rest of the system and to the development of software modules capable of managing it, receiving and processing the data it generates. Both the hardware platforms and software tools should, as far as possible, be developed or selected with these requirements in mind, to minimize their integration overhead.

2.1.5 The testing

As soon as the initial prototypes are finalized, testing should begin to verify their functionality and confirm the validity of the design decisions made up to that point.

^{III}Consider, *e.g.*, feedback control algorithms.

Bearing in mind that a generic and universal testing procedure cannot be defined for all types of autonomous systems, it can generally be expected that once hardware functionality is confirmed, attention will shift to software validation. Debugging software running on an autonomous system is generally more challenging than debugging common application software due to several specific factors:

- It is more difficult to trace program execution on an autonomous, potentially mobile device: direct access to the system may not be available, and the tools at hand are often limited or not very sophisticated.
- In the event of issues, both the software and hardware in use must be re-checked, as the problem could stem from hardware faults or incorrect use of the hardware.
- Conducting tests is not as simple as running a program and reviewing its results: the safety of the apparatus and its operators must be ensured throughout the entire procedure, which can make even the organization of a test a challenging task.

Given the difficulty and importance of this phase, it is reasonable to employ tools and methodologies that can facilitate these tasks as much as possible, ideally those that have already been adequately validated.

2.2 Fundamental requirements

The challenges outlined in the previous section are not exhaustive, nor are they entirely independent of each other. They are, however, representative of the issues that typically arise when designing an autonomous system. Summarizing briefly the many aspects previously covered, suppose that the task at hand is that of developing

an autonomous system capable of performing a series of operations. It is reasonable, in the context of this work, to focus on situations that meet the following assumptions:

- The system has a physical structure that can be modeled as a dynamic system, thus, one of the tasks consists in stabilizing and controlling this dynamic system, something that is commonly referred to in the following as *low-level control* or simply *control*.
- Digital programmable computers of different kinds are used to both develop and run all the algorithms, ranging from low-level control to task planning and supervision.

Note that the situations hereby described might span from mobile robots to drones and even power plants, all classes of systems that have been subject of the author's research work. Recalling Section 2.1, a series of choices regarding the following items must be made:

- sensors and actuators to use;
- software tools and packages to employ and integrate;
- hardware platforms, *i.e.*, onboard electronics to adopt.

Note how these items might be strongly interconnected. Low-level hardware must be chosen according to the control objective for the underlying dynamic system, while high-level hardware must be selected usually weighing the software that it will run against the physical capabilities, as well as the costs, of the system that is going to host it. Finally, software tools and packages can be divided in two groups: that which has to be developed from scratch, possibly very specific to the system at hand, and that

which can be reused from existing libraries or frameworks. The latter category, for example, includes solutions for data processing, communication, and visualization, as well as remote access and monitoring tools; when one wants to develop the prototype of an autonomous system, especially for research purposes, these things are often overlooked, but they are crucial for the system to be usable and maintainable and the overhead that they might introduce can easily become significant if not properly managed early on.

There is a principle in Computer Science [1], dating back to the very early days of the discipline, stating that to do a proper job *no problem should ever be solved twice* or, in a historical fashion, *one must never reinvent the wheel* with the only exception of building a better wheel. One can see how this fits perfectly in the context of the development of autonomous systems: there are a wide range of complex foundational and integration problems to solve which concern the very base of any such system, and thus present themselves each time a new one is developed. Since the author has spent a significant amount of time and effort solving these problems while working on projects whose ultimate goal was that of advancing research in the field of autonomous dynamic systems, the scope of this work is to provide a solution that is *reusable*, *modular*, and *maintainable*, and that can be used as a foundation for the development of innovative prototypes and products. With this in mind, the following requirements are formally identified:

(M) Modularity The architecture must constitute both a development and deployment framework for solutions ranging from single hardware or software modules, meant to be easily integrated and reused, to entire autonomous systems prototypes. To guarantee this, the structure of the framework must suit both these use cases: single modules must carry with them all their dependencies,

and it must be possible to easily *merge* single modules to build a “superproject” out of many “subprojects”.

(D) Development The architecture must support the development of single modules both as standalone packages, and when part of the software suite of a prototype, *i.e.*, while working on a superproject that integrates a module, it must be possible to modify and update the module, easily propagating the updates to every other superproject which integrates that module, unless such superproject has been specifically configured to use a different version of the module.

(H) Hardware The architecture must offer a *hardware abstraction layer*, *i.e.*, it must make it possible to carry on all the development activities without having to care too much about the underlying hardware on which a module or prototype software suite will be deployed, apart from eventual specific dependencies, and it must ease deployment by offering a common framework across multiple different hardware platforms. In the end, the architecture shall offer very similar, if not equal, development and execution environments across different hardware platforms, requiring minimal effort to be replicated.

(O) Overhead The architecture must be as lightweight as possible, in terms of both computational and storage resources. This is to ensure that the overhead introduced by the framework itself is minimal, and that the resources of the hardware platforms on which the framework is deployed can be used to their full potential for the tasks that the system is meant to perform.

Note that these requirements, if examined by the perspective of subjects such as systems engineering, might not appear well-posed due to, *e.g.*, the lack of a clear and objective way to evaluate them. This is intended though, since they are meant to guide the design of an architecture and not that of a specific system. Moreover, the

design stage at which they are introduced is one in which many things still have to be evaluated such as, *e.g.*, hardware platforms to support and preexisting software tools to integrate, and thus the final definition of the architecture will be the result of many trade-offs. They are high-level requirements meant to guide the design process, characterizing the solution that must be developed from a broad and functional point of view.

Coming back to the generic, although representative, example provided at the beginning of this Section, it appears clear how a framework that meets these requirements would be beneficial, cutting down to the minimum all of the overhead that is usually due to integration and basic organization activities in the development of an autonomous system. Such an architecture would, in fact, provide a common base layer that would both allow developers and teams to focus on their project- or research-specific tasks in a common environment, and ensure that all the work done is reusable, maintainable, and easily deployable on a variety of hardware platforms, ideally ranging from the simplest SoC to the most complex general-purpose computer.

2.3 Related works

To further motivate the premises of this work, this Section presents some of the most relevant solutions that have been proposed in recent years to address the issues outlined in Section 2.1. The list, although short, is in fact exhaustive: to the best of the author's knowledge, and at the time of writing, no other such framework has been developed and proposed in the scientific literature. Furthermore, a review of the works presented hereafter would reveal to the interested reader that none of them fully meets the requirements identified in Section 2.2, especially those that deal with the independence from the underlying hardware and the construction of a replicable

development environment. Finally, to discuss the following, it is inevitable to mention solutions and tools which will be the subject of subsequent Chapters: they will be presented in due detail in the following, while proper references are provided here.

2.3.1 RoboStack

The RoboStack framework [2], published in 2022 and maintained ever since, constitutes a first promising solution to the challenges outlined in Section 2.1. RoboStack is a collection of software packages built on the Conda package management system [3], which has become the de-facto standard in both industry and academia for the management of Python *environments*, a concept that has gained particular interest in the scientific community in recent years thanks to the popularity of Python as a programming language in contexts like big data processing, statistics, machine learning, and artificial intelligence. The Conda package manager allows to specify a set of software modules to be collected and installed in an isolated location, together with their specific versions in case such a level of granularity becomes necessary. Once such a configuration is specified, it can be replicated with ease on any other machine and filesystem path, regardless of the operating system and many other factors, thus providing a way to ensure that the software environment in which a program is developed and run is always the same. RoboStack builds on this concept, providing a wide set of software packages and libraries that are commonly used in the development of robotic systems, such as the Robot Operating System (ROS) and the Gazebo simulator, illustrated in [TODO ROS sec. ref.](#), and that are sometimes difficult to install and configure correctly, especially on embedded platforms. The framework is designed to be used in conjunction with the Conda package manager, thus supporting a variety of operating systems ranging from Linux to Windows and macOS, and it is meant to be installed on machines that will be used for the development of robotic systems,

deploying environments through the selection of specific sets of packages to install in each. This solution, although promising and already widely applicable, does not completely meet the requirements previously identified, for three reasons. First, it is entirely dependent on Conda which, although a very powerful tool, may not be the best choice in terms of *isolation* of the software environment: while Conda allows one to install software packages in an isolated location, it does not provide a way to define a specific portion of system resources to offer to that software, a feature nowadays informally called *containerization* and explained later on, which could be useful to further tune the performance of the software running on the system and ensure that the host OS installation stays intact. Second, every piece of software must be added to RoboStack to be installed in one of its environments, which means that the framework is not as flexible as it could be, as that it is not possible to install any software package available from any source out of the box; the addition process requires a variable amount of work, particularly due to the many dependencies a software module may have, as explained in [2]. Last, RoboStack is dependent on Jupyter for development, which is not the best choice in terms of development environments. While Jupyter is a very powerful tool, its main purpose remains that for which it has been originally developed: offering a way to write and run Python code multiple times in interactive notebooks displayed in a web browser, which is not really adherent to the scenario outlined at the beginning of this Chapter which involves developing and testing in real time the software that will run on an autonomous system. Moreover, many plugins existing for other visualizers and IDEs, some of which are presented in the following Sections, have to be reimplemented to be used in a Jupyter environment, which is not always possible or convenient. These limitations, although not critical, make RoboStack not the best choice for the development of autonomous systems, especially when the requirements identified in Section 2.2 are taken into account.

2.3.2 eProsima Vulcanexus

The Vulcanexus software suite [4] developed by eProsima, originally released in early 2023, poses itself as a simple framework for the development of autonomous robotic systems. The suite is composed of a set of software packages that are meant to be installed either on a host operating system or inside a *container* managed by, *e.g.*, the Docker Engine presented in [TODO Docker sec. ref.](#). The suite is fairly lightweight but nonetheless comprehensive: it provides the Robot Operating System 2 (ROS 2) middleware, together with the Fast DDS by eProsima implementation of the Data Distribution Service (DDS) communication middleware introduced in [TODO DDS sec. ref.](#), plus some more software tools aimed at more specific scenarios like, *e.g.*, that of microcontrollers. Moreover, the fact that it is shipped also as a Docker image, compatible with different hardware platforms, adds some flexibility to it in terms of isolation of both the development and execution environments with respect to, *e.g.*, the aforementioned RoboStack framework. However, the major limitation of this framework lies in the fact that its features more or less end here. With respect to the requirements listed in Section 2.2, no effort is made towards the construction of a modular development and deployment environment, nor towards the support to a wide range of hardware platforms, especially in the case of SoCs aimed at robotic systems which, as will be explained later on, are gaining an increasing interest by the scientific community but require a fair amount of effort to be correctly set up. Furthermore, the restriction to the Fast DDS communication middleware for ROS 2, although evidently motivated by the fact that it is also developed by eProsima, hinders the flexibility of the framework in terms of communication protocols, an aspect that becomes critical in some operational scenarios where, *e.g.*, a lossy network is involved, as explained in [TODO tools comms. sec. ref.](#).

2.3.3 NASA F Prime

The F Prime framework [5], developed in the United States by the Jet Propulsion Laboratory (JPL) of the National Aeronautics and Space Administration (NASA) and published in 2018, is currently one of the solutions that better fit the requirements listed in Section 2.2. It is a lightweight, modular, and open-source framework for the development and deployment of software for small atmospheric and orbital vehicles like the CubeSats and the Mars Helicopter prototype. It provides the foundations for a software architecture oriented at flight control in which software modules, written in the C++ and Python programming languages, can be loaded and configured easily as *components* of the architecture itself. The framework, due to its organization, encourages the development of software packages meant to be published and reused among subsequent missions and prototype developments. Moreover, the framework offers ad-hoc communication primitives and services, as well as some thread scheduling capabilities, to ensure that software tasks in the architecture meet their real-time requirements, an aspect that is crucial in flight and space operations. Finally, thanks to its light organization and basic system requirements, it supports a wide variety of general-purpose and real-time operating systems (RTOS) and can easily be compiled on many hardware architectures. This framework is very promising and shows a lot of potential, but still does not fully meet the aforementioned requirements, mainly because of its limited diffusion and specialized scope. Although it is open-source, it is aimed at a very specific scientific sector, that of space missions, thus receiving limited acclaim outside of such area. Moreover, a downside of its lightweight nature is that it offers limited support for the integration of third-party modules and libraries, a fact which limits the capability of the framework of being used in a wider range of scenarios comprising, *e.g.*, that of swarm aerial robotics, as well as the potential benefit of contributions from the scientific community. Finally, as declared in [5],

in its current version it depends on commercial, licensed software for some of its functionalities, which could be a limitation for users outside NASA and JPL.

2.3.4 MARTe2

The MARTe2 framework, standing for *Multi-threaded Application Real-Time executor* 2 [6], is the second qualified framework that is presented in this Section. Originally developed in 2005 by a team of nuclear fusion researchers at the Joint European Torus (JET) UK facility and then registered as a work of the Fusion For Energy (F4E) european organization, it has been under active development ever since and is currently employed in many nuclear fusion research facilities around the world. As its name suggests, it is a framework aimed at the development of real-time software control architectures. It is written in C++ and supports only this programming language. Its organization is actually the closest to what is requested in Section 2.2 and thus deserves a little deeper analysis. It is composed by a core set of libraries plus a set of optional "components" that add specific functionalities or support for particular hardware devices, algorithms, communication protocols, etc. As illustrated in Figure 2.1, the core libraries are divided in three distinct groups:

- **BareMetal**: a set of libraries that implement basic functionalities ranging from data types and hardware abstraction, to communication primitives and logging, and provide the definition of base classes that can be used to develop new components of an architecture.
- **FileSystem**: these libraries provide functionalities to read and write data from and to files, as well as to manage the configuration of the system and the logging of the data produced by the components.

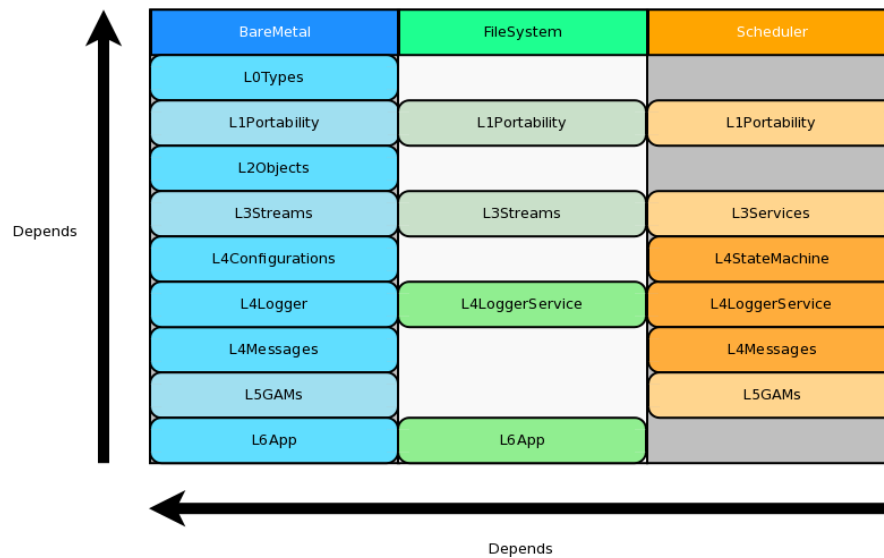


Figure 2.1: Organization of the core libraries of the MARTe2 framework.

- **Scheduler:** libraries in this group implement real-time thread schedulers and their algorithms, as well as models such as state machines that can be useful to keep track of the state of a software component or algorithm.

Moreover, note that libraries in each group follow a hierarchical organization, with those on the lower levels providing basic functionalities and those on the higher levels providing more complex and specialized ones. All of the framework and its components can be built using the GNU^{IV} make tool, as every MARTe2 software package comes with its own `Makefile` and the entire framework relies on a system of Makefiles that define environment variables and search paths for the compiler, then finally invoke it. The vision guiding the structure of the framework, although it has now reached a maturity that could make it applicable also in contexts that are completely different from nuclear fusion, *e.g.* again, that of robotics, is still that of its early days: implement real-time software control architectures for physics research plants. Thus, its scope has remained the same ever since: managing software units

^{IV}GNU is Not Unix, <https://www.gnu.org/>.

that run *algorithms* and exchange *data* organized in *signals*, which are collections of data of a specific type and dimension, modeling algebraic objects ranging from scalars to vectors and matrices. This idea reflects the main classes of software components that can be found and implemented in any MARTe2-based architecture, and that are the following:

- DataSource: a component that exchanges data organized in signals with the external world, *e.g.*, a hardware device or another software component.
- Broker: a component that manages the exchange of signals between higher-level components and DataSources, implementing memory synchronization schemes if required.
- GAM: short for *Generic Application Module*, a component that implements an algorithm that processes input signals and produces output ones, *e.g.*, a control algorithm or a data filtering algorithm.

Finally, a MARTe2-based architecture is usually divided in one or more applications, intended as processes running on the host machine, which contain a number of components specified in a configuration file together with their configuration parameters. Such configuration files, informally named *cfgs*, have a specific syntax, allowing an application to be built by literally "assembling" portions of a configuration file that define the components and their parameters, and then running the application with a specific configuration file that specifies the components to be loaded at run time, plus the settings for the OS scheduler. The reason why this work exists and MARTe2, although being the most promising solution, is still found in this Section, is that as every other work hereby discussed it has its own downsides that set it a bit too much apart from the requirements stated earlier in this Chapter. The first ones descend from

its original scope, and recall the ones commonly found in previously examined works: it has been developed to aid in a very specific scientific research field, that of nuclear fusion in this case, and thus found very little to no adoption in the years outside of it; this translates to limited improvements over the original organization, and lack of support for modern technologies, third-party libraries, and use cases. The code organization and build system described early on is functional and efficient but follows old practices, like the focus on signals rather than software components, and relies on tools like `make` which, although standard and widely adopted, have nowadays been superseded by more modern solutions which are more suited to the management of large and modular codebases. Due to its strict real-time nature, MARTe2 also imposes some restrictions on the development of software modules, which must be written in C++ and must adhere to old language standards, lacking modern features and erecting a barrier against the integration of many open-source libraries and tools. The direct experience of the author, which worked with this framework in both research and didactic settings, suggests that these facts, together with the effective but cryptic syntax of the `cfgs`, make MARTe2 a very powerful but also clunky framework which often scares away newcomers and makes it difficult to maintain and evolve the software architectures built with it. Finally, although its compilation requires very little features from the host system, it is not officially supported on architectures other than x86 and requires a tailored OS kernel to fully exploit its real-time capabilities, limiting its application in practice to Linux-based systems if one wants the smoothest possible usage experience.

3 Tools for the job

The previous Chapters highlighted the need for a new software architecture that may constitute the foundational layer of distributed autonomous systems, and provided a solid set of requirements that can drive its design. Existing frameworks have been reviewed, some of which provided valuable insights and ideas about how to address some of the design challenges, but none ultimately offering the complete set of features required. Before presenting the design of the solution that this work proposes, it is important to delve further into a point that the previous discussion shed light onto: there are solutions available, in both the literature, the industry, and the open-source software community, that can be employed to address some of the key issues that the requirements identify. Following the computer science design principle recalled in Section 2.2, that is, to not reinvent the wheel, it would be wise to review these tools and see how they can be integrated in the proposed solution. This Chapter provides such an overview: for each tool, its necessity will first be motivated by illustrating a problem that is common in the development of distributed autonomous systems, and then the tool itself will be presented, along with a brief discussion of its features and limitations. Note that the aim of this work is to provide a general-purpose software architecture, so not all of the solutions presented in this Chapter, as well as all the features that the proposed architecture will have, may be necessary or even beneficial in every practical context. However, the goal is to provide a solution that can be adapted to a wide range

of applications, as a good toolbox to have at hand, offering a set of features that can be configured and used as needed.

3.1 Inter-process communication: the middleware

When developing distributed systems composed of many modules, especially software ones, the transmission of data among them becomes a topic of paramount importance. Note that this issue concerns both transmissions happening between software modules running on the same host and on different hosts. Moreover, alongside this topic there is that of *intra-process communication*, that is, the organization and regulation of data exchanges among different threads running in a same process. Examples of situations in which many software modules may coexist inside a single process, and why such a situation may be desirable, are presented and discussed in the following, for now let us focus on the general problem of inter-process communication and simply note that in the majority of the situations, this other problem can be solved by employing either the same tools that are used for inter-process communication, or simpler ones based on shared memory areas guarded by synchronization primitives. One has, in general, to figure out a variety of issues such as the following:

- **Data formatting**, *i.e.*, how information that should travel from one module to another should be encoded and structured in packets or similar entities.
- **Data serialization and deserialization**, *i.e.*, how packets should be transformed into a format that can be transmitted over a medium, which is usually some kind of point-to-point connection or a network.
- **Data transmission**, *i.e.*, how packets should be sent and received, and how the system should react to errors or delays in the transmission; this also includes

things like reliability requirements, that is, whether the system should guarantee that a packet is delivered, and how many times it should try to deliver it if it fails.

The points listed above are usually dealt with by employing a specific *protocol*, that is, a predefined set of rules that regulate all those aspects of the communication. All the software that composes the system should adopt such protocol, which is usually implemented in a set of libraries that can be used in the code. However, dealing directly with networking protocols might slow down the development process: the host system configuration usually becomes very important, since all the operating systems involved must agree on the protocol implementation to support and use, and a lot of work may become necessary to proficiently use all the protocol APIs to achieve all the desired communication features and behaviors. Let us remember that this is not the original task: the goal is to develop a distributed autonomous system, and to write software for it, thus it would be desirable to have a tool that abstracts all the networking details and provides a simple and easy-to-use API that makes data transmission in software modules a straightforward operation, from both the coding and implementation points of view. This is where a particular kind of software, historically denoted by the term *middleware*, comes into play. To grasp its importance in the context of this work, a step back in time is necessary.

In 1968, a conference sponsored by the Science Committee of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) was held in Garmisch, Germany, on the topic of software development. Although not widely discussed, it was a historically significant event in this field: it provided a comprehensive overview of the design practices and methodologies used by leading companies in the growing and highly competitive field of computing. The goal was to identify standard strategies for addressing common problems. It should be noted that at that time, and for at least another fifteen years,

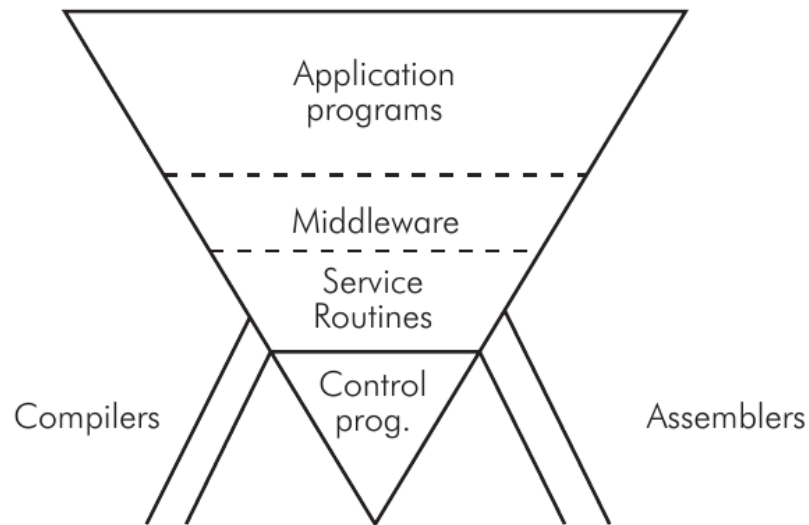


Figure 3.1: Software organization in a general-purpose computer, as presented at the 1968 NATO conference on software engineering.

there were virtually no standards in computer production and programming. Each company offered its own product developed from scratch, in both hardware and software. Standardization and collaboration among various manufacturers began only when information started being exchanged between different computers, first through storage media and later over the Internet, alongside a growing demand for new types of devices and standard formats to adopt when sharing data. A fairly complete transcription of the conference can be found in [7]. It includes the first official mentions of several concepts well known today, such as *component design* and *unit testing*. However, of particular relevance to this work is the representation of the hierarchical structure of software presented by one of the speakers. This structure, valid even today with certain extensions, is illustrated in the inverted pyramid scheme shown in Figure 3.1. The idea is that a complex system is like an inverted pyramid: it cannot remain operational without adequate support provided by secondary components. These might be completely invisible to the end user and thus may be considered somewhat external, yet are of vital importance for the correct functioning of the

whole: *compilers* and *assemblers*, for instance, which are programs that translate code written in a given language first into the target architecture's assembly language and then into binary machine language, typically generating an executable file at the end of the processing pipeline. These tools must be reliable and efficient, as the implementation of everything else depends on them. Next, we have the layers of *Control Programs* and *Service Routines*: these are what we today call the *operating system* and *device drivers*. They are typically developed with a strong dependence on the machine at hand, considering its specific characteristics, and heavily depend on the employed compilation tools. Their role is to provide an abstraction of the hardware that makes its use simple both for the end user, who interacts with applications, and for application developers themselves. The application software is precisely what we find in the topmost layer: programs that use the hardware more or less directly to provide various services to users. There is, however, an intermediate layer that is often overlooked because it was not always present or was difficult to characterize in the past: the *middleware*. Situated between system software and application software, middleware found its first definition and characterization at the aforementioned conference. Initially conceived merely as a connective layer between current and *legacy* software, middleware provides services and functionalities common to applications beyond what the operating system offers, building itself on top of it and abstracting its own implementation and protocol details. From the perspective offered by the topmost level of the inverted pyramid it appears as normal application software, often consisting of shared or dynamic libraries. Middleware typically offers services to programmers aimed at, *e.g.*, data management, communication, and authentication. Therefore, middleware aids developers in building applications more efficiently by acting as a connective tissue between applications, data, and users. In distributed environments, middleware can facilitate the development and execution of large-scale

applications. A typical service offered by middleware is a method for data exchange between applications, even across different devices, according to a common format referred to as an *interface*, which is defined as needed. In general, the services offered by middleware are specified only in terms of their dynamics but can be implemented on different architectures and devices, functioning consistently while keeping their implementation hidden from both the application programmer and the end user. For example, when middleware handles communication between applications, it might position itself within the network stack between the transport and application layers¹. Today, middleware can be categorized into two types: that which operates in *human time*, designed for direct use by human users (*e.g.*, web services), and that which operates in *machine time*, composed mainly of APIs that application developers can use to facilitate their work, benefiting from increased portability across a wide variety of devices. In light of all this, and considering the common difficulties faced when designing the software for a distributed autonomous system, it becomes clear how adopting communication middleware to solve the problem of data exchange among modules can simplify things: many functionalities that would have to be implemented from scratch would instead be offered by the middleware itself as services to be employed in the programs being developed. The selection of this particular class of middleware is again motivated by both the current trends in the software industry pertaining to the development of autonomous systems, and to the author's experience in the field during the years that led to this work.

The rest of this section will introduce three specific middlewares that are widely used in the industry and in the open-source community, and that have become of pivotal importance in the two practical scenarios considered later in this work as a

¹Considering the TCP/IP model, which is a four-layers reduction of the original seven-layers Open Systems Interconnection (OSI) model of the networking protocol stack.

specialization of the proposed architecture: that of autonomous robotics and that of power plants. The first middleware is the *Data Distribution Service* (DDS), which has been the first to provide a standard for data exchange in distributed systems, followed by the Zenoh middleware which addresses some of the limitations of DDS, and finally the *Robot Operating System* (ROS), which is a middleware specifically designed for robotics applications. All these three components will be included in the architecture proposed in the following Chapters, making some of its foundational layers.

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